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Twitter's former Trust and Safety head details the challenges facing decentralized social platforms

[Yoel Roth](#), [previously](#) the head of Twitter's Trust and Safety, [now at Match Group](#), is sharing his concerns about the future of the open social web and its ability to combat misinformation, spam, and other illegal content, like child sexual abuse material (CSAM). In a recent interview, Roth worried about the lack of moderation tools available to the fediverse — the open social web that includes apps like Mastodon, Threads, Pixelfed, and others, as well as other open platforms like Bluesky.

He also reminisced about key moments in Trust and Safety at Twitter, like its decision to ban President Trump from the platform, the misinformation spread by Russian bot farms, and how Twitter's own users, including CEO Jack Dorsey, fell prey to bots.

IMAGE CREDITS: BRYCE DURBIN / TECHCRUNCH

On the podcast [revolution.social with @Rabble](#), Roth pointed out that the efforts at building more democratically run online communities across the open social web are also those that have the fewest resources when it comes to moderation tools.

“...looking at Mastodon, looking at other services based on ActivityPub [protocol], looking at Bluesky in its earliest days, and then looking at Threads as Meta started to develop it, what we saw was that a lot of the services that were leaning the hardest into community-based control gave their communities the least technical tools to be able to administer their policies,” Roth said.

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He also saw a “pretty big backslide” on the open social web when it came to the transparency and decision legitimacy that Twitter once had. While, arguably, many at the time disagreed with Twitter’s decision to ban Trump, the company explained its rationale for doing so. Now, social media providers are so concerned about preventing bad actors from gaming them that they rarely explain themselves.

Meanwhile, on many open social platforms, users wouldn’t receive a notice about their banned posts, and their posts would just vanish — there wasn’t even an indication to others that the post used to exist.

“I don’t blame startups for being startups, or new pieces of software for lacking all the bells and whistles, but if the whole point of the project was increasing democratic legitimacy of governance, and what we’ve done is take a step back on governance, then, has this actually worked at all?” Roth wonders.

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The economics of moderation

He also brought up the issues around the economics of moderation and how the federated approach hasn't yet been sustainable on this front.

For instance, an organization called IFTAS (Independent Federated Trust & Safety) had been working to build moderation tools for the fediverse, including providing the fediverse with access to tools to combat CSAM, but it ran out of money and [had to shut down many](#) of its projects earlier in 2025.

“We saw it coming two years ago. IFTAS saw it coming. Everybody who's been working in this space is largely volunteering their time and efforts, and that only goes so far, because at some point, people have families and need to pay bills, and compute costs stack up if you need to run ML models to detect certain types of bad content,” he explained. “It just all gets expensive, and the economics of this federated approach to trust and safety never quite added up. And in my opinion, still don't.”

Bluesky, meanwhile, has chosen to employ moderators and hire in trust and safety, but it limits itself to the moderation of its own app. Plus, they're providing tools that let people customize their own moderation preferences.

“They’re doing this work at scale. There’s obviously room for improvement. I’d love to see them be a bit more transparent. But, fundamentally, they’re doing the right stuff,” Roth said. However, as the service further decentralizes, Bluesky will face questions about when it is the responsibility to protect the individual over the needs of the community, he notes.

For example, with doxxing, it’s possible that someone wouldn’t see that their personal information was being spread online because of how they configured their moderation tools. But it should still be someone’s responsibility to enforce those protections, even if the user isn’t on the main Bluesky app.

Where to draw the line on privacy

Another issue facing the fediverse is that the decision to favor privacy can thwart moderation attempts. While Twitter tried not to store personal data it didn’t need to, it still collected things like the IP address of the user, when they accessed the service, device identifiers, and more. These helped the company when it needed to do forensic analysis of something like a Russian troll farm.

Fediverse admins, meanwhile, may not even be collecting the necessary logs or won’t view them if they think it’s a violation of user privacy.

But the reality is that without data, it’s harder to determine who’s really a bot.

Roth offered a few examples of this from his Twitter days, noting how it became a trend for users to reply “bot” to anyone they disagreed with. He says that he initially set up an alert and reviewed all these posts manually, examining hundreds of

instances of “bot” accusations, and nobody was ever right. Even Twitter co-founder and former CEO Jack Dorsey fell victim, retweeting posts [from a Russian actor who claimed to be Crystal Johnson](#), a Black woman from New York.

“The CEO of the company liked this content, amplified it, and had no way of knowing as a user that Crystal Johnson was actually a Russian troll,” Roth said.

The role of AI

One timely topic of discussion was how AI was changing the landscape. Roth referenced recent research from Stanford that found that, in a political context, large language models (LLMs) could even be more convincing than humans when properly tuned.

That means a solution that relies only on content analysis itself isn’t enough.

Instead, companies need to track other behavioral signals — like if some entity is creating multiple accounts, using automation to post, or posting at weird times of day that correspond to different time zones, he suggested.

“These are behavioral signals that are latent even in really convincing content. And I think that’s where you have to start this,” Roth said. “If you’re starting with the content, you’re in an arms race against leading AI models and you’ve already lost.”

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Why Meta is looking to the fediverse as the future for social media

Sarah Perez — 1:37 PM PDT · April 25, 2024

Meta’s move into the open social web, also known as the fediverse, is puzzling. Does the Facebook

owner see open protocols as the future? Will it [embrace the fediverse only to shut it down](#), shifting people back to its proprietary platforms and decimating startups building in the space? Will it bring its advertising empire to the fediverse, where today clients like Mastodon and others remain ad-free?

One possible answer can be teased out of a conversation between two Meta employees working on Threads and [Flipboard](#) CEO Mike McCue, whose [company joined the fediverse](#) with its [support of ActivityPub](#), the protocol that powers Mastodon and others.

On McCue’s “Flipboard Dot Social” [podcast](#), he spoke to two leaders building the Threads experience, director of product management Rachel Lambert and software engineer Peter Cottle. McCue raised questions and concerns shared by others working on fediverse projects, including what Meta’s involvement means for this space, and whether Meta would eventually abandon Threads and the fediverse, leaving a destroyed ecosystem in its wake.

Lambert responded by pointing out that Meta has other open source efforts in the works, so “pulling the rug” on its fediverse work would come at a “very high cost” for the company, since it would be detrimental to Meta’s work trying to build trust with other open source communities.

For example, the company is releasing some of its work [on large language models \(LLMs\) as open source products](#), like Llama.

In addition, she believes that Meta will be able to continue to build trust over time with those working in the fediverse by releasing features and hitting milestones, as it did recently with the launch of the new toggle that lets Threads users [publish their](#)

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[posts to the wider fediverse](#), where they can be viewed on Mastodon and other apps.

But more importantly, McCue (and all of us) wanted to know: Why is Meta engaged with the fediverse to begin with?



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Meta today has [3.24 billion people using its social apps](#) daily, according to its Q1 2024 earnings. Does it really need a few million more?

Lambert answered this question indirectly by explaining the use case for Threads as a place to have public conversations in real time. She suggested that connecting to the fediverse would help users find a broader audience than those they could reach on Threads alone.

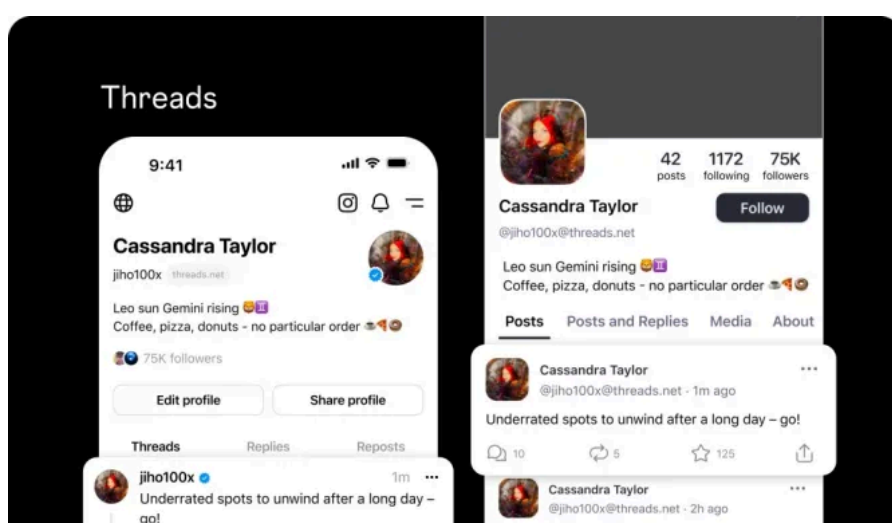
That's only true to a point, however. While the fediverse is active and growing, Threads is already a dominant app in the space. Outside of Threads' [now 150 million monthly active users](#), the wider fediverse has just [north of 10 million users](#).

Mastodon, a top federated app, has fallen [below 1 million monthly](#) active users after Threads launched.

So if Threads joining the fediverse is not about significantly widening creators' reach, then what is Meta's aim?

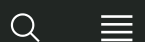
The Meta employees' remarks hinted at a broader reason behind Meta's shift to the fediverse.

Bringing the creator economy to the open social web



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wanted to leave Meta for other social apps where they had more direct relationships with fans, there

are still few sizable options outside of TikTok and YouTube.

If those creators joined the fediverse — perhaps to get away from Meta’s hold on their livelihoods — Threads users would still benefit from their content. (Cue “[*Hotel California*](#)“).

Later in the podcast, Cottle expands on how this could play out at the protocol level, as well, if creators offered their followers the ability to pay for access to their content.

“You could imagine an extension to the protocol eventually — of saying like, ‘I want to support micropayments,’ or ... like, ‘hey, feel free to show me ads, if that supports you.’ Kind of like a way for you to self-label or self-opt-in. That would be great,” Cottle noted, speaking casually. Whether or not Meta would find a way to get a cut of those micropayments, of course, remains to be seen.

McCue riffed on the idea that fediverse users could become creators where some of their content became available to subscribers only, similar to how Patreon works. For instance, fediverse advocate and co-editor of ActivityPub [Evan Prodromou](#) created a paid Mastodon account ([@evanplus@prodromou.pub](#)) that users could subscribe to for \$5 per month to gain access. If he’s on board with paid content, surely others would follow. Cottle agreed that the model could work with the fediverse, too.

He additionally suggested there are ways the fediverse could monetize beyond donations, which is what often powers various efforts today, like Mastodon. Cottle said someone might even make a fediverse experience that consumers would pay for, the way some fediverse client apps are paid today.

“The servers aren’t free to run. And eventually, somebody needs to find a way to ... sustain the costs of the business,” he pointed out. Could Meta be pondering a paid federated experience, [like Medium launched?](#)

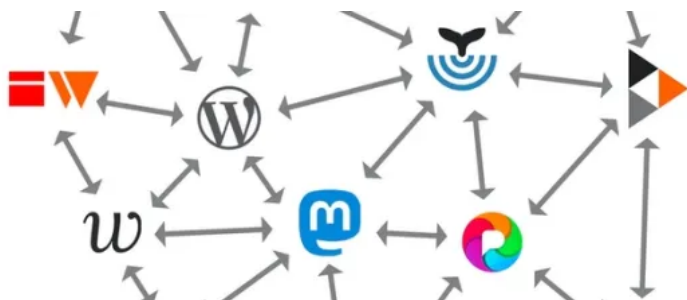
Moderation services at the protocol level

The podcast yielded another possible answer as to what Meta may be working on in the space, with a suggestion that it could bring its moderation expertise to the ActivityPub protocol.

“A lot of the instruments that we have for people to feel safe and to feel like they’re able to personalize their experience are pretty blunt today. So, you can block users ... you can do server-level blocking overall, which is a really big action, but you’re kind of missing some other tools in there that are a little bit more like proportional response,” explained Lambert.

Today, fediverse users can’t do things like filter their followers or replies for offensive content or behavior in the same way as they can on Instagram. “That would be great for us to develop as more of a standard at the protocol level,” she added. (Of note, [Threads just launched the ability](#) to filter out words, phrases, and emoji and added tools to mute notifications and controls for quote posts.)

Still, Lambert said that whatever work Meta does it wouldn’t expect everyone in the fediverse to adopt its own toolkit.



“We’ve built our technology around a set of policies, and our policies are informed by a lot of different inputs from civil rights groups, policy stakeholders, and just the values of our company, generally. So we certainly wouldn’t want to presume that that is now the standard within the fediverse for how to do moderate, but making those tools more available so people have that option seems like a really compelling path from our perspective.”

Meta’s plan also sounds a lot like Bluesky’s idea around [stackable moderation services](#), where third parties [can offer moderation services](#) on top of Bluesky either as independent projects from individuals or communities or even as paid subscription products.

Perhaps Meta, too, sees a future where its existing moderation capabilities become a subscription revenue product across the wider open social web.

Finally, Lambert described a fediverse user experience where you could follow the conversations taking place around a post across multiple servers more easily.

“I think that in combination with the tools that allow you to personalize that experience will ... help people feel more safe and in control,” she said.

Threads launches custom mute filters, teases controls for quote posts



Threads and Instagram head Adam Mosseri announced today that Threads is launching a new feature that lets users filter out words and phrases from their feeds and mentions. The “Hidden Words” feature automatically mutes common words, phrases, and emojis that might be offensive to users. In addition to these preset filters, users can add their ... [Continue reading](#)

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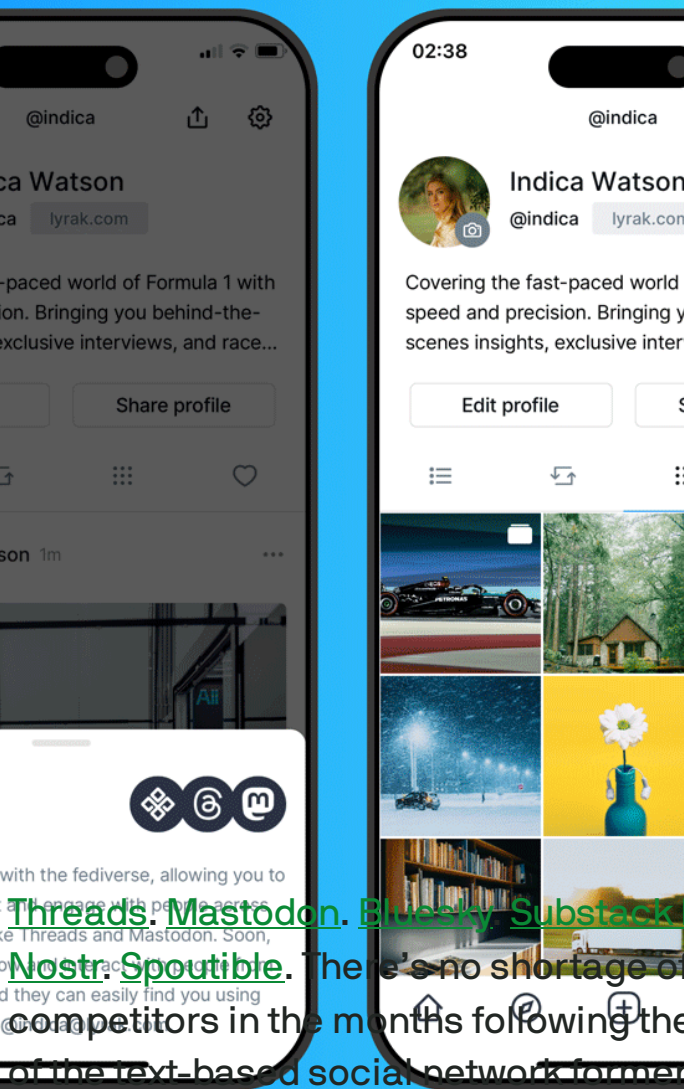
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Lyrak to take on X by combining the best of Twitter with fediverse integration

Sarah Perez — 8:55 AM PDT · April 11, 2024



Threads. Mastodon. Bluesky. Substack. Notes. Post. Nostr. Spoutable. There's no shortage of X

competitors in the months following the acquisition of the text-based social network formerly known as

Twitter by Elon Musk. Now you can add one more startup to that lineup: **Lyrak**, a new X rival that aims to differentiate itself by focusing on real-time news and monetization options for creators, as on X, but with fediverse integrations, similar to Instagram's Threads.

IMAGE CREDITS: LYRAK

The fediverse refers to the open source social network of interconnected servers powered by the social networking protocol ActivityPub. Mastodon is the most well-known among the federated social apps, but even Meta has sensed a shift in the direction of the web and built its latest social network, Threads, with an eye toward ActivityPub integrations.

With **Lyrak**, the plan is to take the best of what Twitter has to offer and combine it with ActivityPub integration, allowing users to interact with a wider

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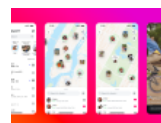
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audience on other federated social networks, like Mastodon and others.

That integration isn't yet live, but the team says it'll begin the work in a few months. Once live, Lyrak users will be able to see posts from Mastodon users and vice versa.

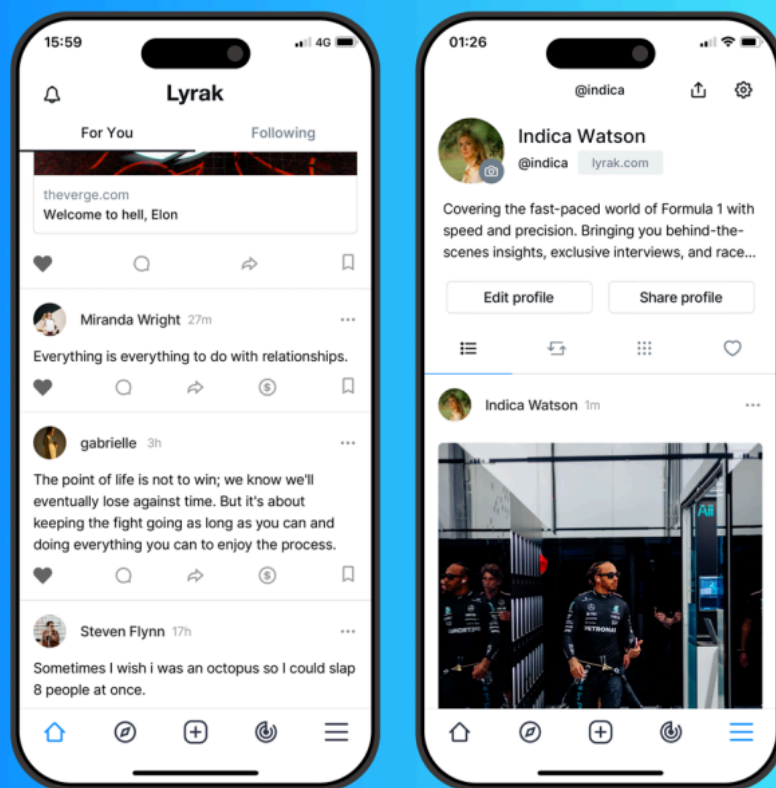


IMAGE CREDITS: LYRAK

Founded by London-based web designer and marketer Rishi Siva, Lyrak is named for a lead character in the TV show “His Dark Materials,” Lyra. Siva says Lyra discovers new worlds, and because Lyrak is also striving to build something better, it seemed like a good source of inspiration.

The founder came up with the idea after spending time helping small businesses set up websites so they could make money on the web and attract customers. At one point, Siva also created a Thumbtack-like app, but the COVID-19 pandemic impacted its ability to grow as many local tradespeople were unable to work at the time.

Still, he expresses a desire to help users to better monetize their content and skills online.



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“Our lower fees and sharing 50% ad revenue with creators further support this goal,” Siva notes.

By comparison, X doesn't publicly share its percentage, which can vary based on the type of post, demographics, geography and other factors. Plus, revenue is only earned for ads [shown to Verified users](#) (paid subscribers).

Siva is also unhappy with the direction X is going and how it affects creators.

“After Musk took over Twitter, I saw a significant change in the way the platform behaved and the types of accounts it promoted. It's disappointing to see that all the tech leaders I admire ignored this and still use Twitter [X],” he noted, pointing to the [issues](#) around [far-right groups](#) and [antisemitic content](#) on X's platform.

However, he admits that Twitter/X still remains the best place for real-time news, which is why it remains sticky with users, despite the changes. Threads, meanwhile, isn't prioritizing real-time news outside of sports; Siva dubs it "basically a text version of Instagram."

He thinks Mastodon and Bluesky will ultimately be too complicated for regular users, but Lyrak could benefit from their networks through fediverse integrations. (Technically, Bluesky is not federated with Mastodon because it uses a different protocol, but work is being done to build bridges between the two.)

IMAGE CREDITS: LYRAK

Lyrak says it will focus initially on getting journalists to join the network, to help it with becoming a real-time social app. To attract them, Lyrak will allow Verified journalists to share content to users' home feeds based on their interests and offer tools to send them notifications to people who regularly click their links. (The latter is similar to Artifact —

[RIP](#) — which would alert users to new articles from [reporters and writers they followed.](#))

The startup will also try to attract people who sell digital products, with specific tools launching for this crowd later in May. Creators will be able to offer subscriptions to their followers as well as collect tips.

Another coming feature will involve AI tools, like an answer engine and user-generated AI characters, also planned for May.

The company plans to generate revenue through ads, like X, but also by taking a 10% cut from paid posts, subscriptions, tips, digital products and other AI features, in time.

To route around app store fees, Lyrak's website will allow users to deposit funds to the app, which they can use to pay creators. (Funds added through in-app purchases will require paying Apple its 30% fee, however.)

Another idea, borrowed from sites like Reddit, is a reputation score that will reflect the value a user brings to the community through their comments, reposts, likes and inviting others to the platform. This will be combined with AI moderation efforts and human moderators to keep the app safe, the team promises.

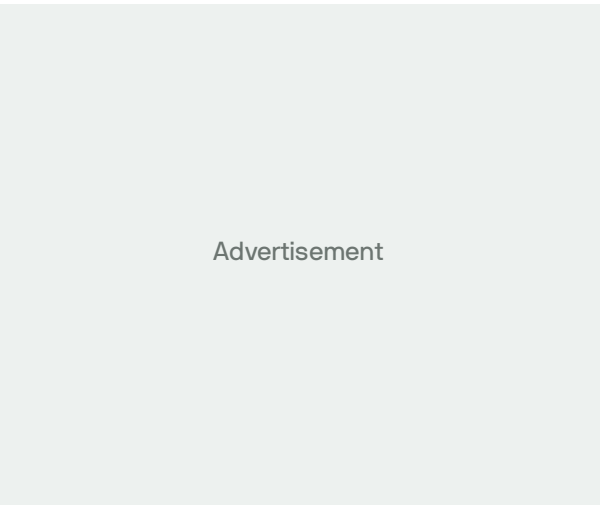
IMAGE CREDITS: LYRAK

“After our initial launch and a couple of weeks of bug fixes, we plan to regularly release new features,” Siva said. “The advantage of being a startup building a social app is that we have a fresh perspective on things. We’re not stuck in the old ways of thinking, which allows us to innovate and create features that truly benefit our users.”

Lyrak is being built by a team of five, most of whom are based in London. (The fifth person is soon moving to London, too.) The startup is currently bootstrapped and available for [download on iOS](#).

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